Notes: Nunn & Wantchekon (AER, 2011)
The Slave Trade and the Origins of Mistrust in Africa

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Can current differences in trust within Africa be traced to the slave trades that affected ancestors several centuries earlier?
- **Core claim.** Individuals from ethnic groups heavily exposed to the transatlantic and Indian Ocean slave trades report lower trust today.
- **Outcome.** Trust is measured using Afrobarometer survey questions about relatives, neighbors, coethnics, other ethnic groups, and local government councils.
- **Treatment.** Historical exposure is measured by the number of slaves taken from each ethnic group, usually using $\ln(1 + \text{exports}/\text{area})$.
- **Mechanism.** The slave trade created incentives for betrayal, kidnapping, and selling even within communities and families, making mistrust an adaptive rule-of-thumb.
- **Identification.** The paper combines OLS with rich controls, Altonji-Elder-Taber selection-on-observables ratios, IV using historical distance from the coast, reduced-form falsification tests, and internal-versus-external channel tests.
- **Main result.** Slave exports are negatively related to all five trust measures; IV estimates are similar in sign and magnitude to OLS estimates.
- **Economic takeaway.** Historical violence can shape persistent cultural norms. Trust today is partly an inherited social response to past environments in which trusting others was dangerous.

2 Incremental contribution of the paper

- **From reduced-form history to mechanism.** Nunn (2008) shows that the slave trade affected long-run African income. This paper examines trust as a mechanism linking the slave trade to contemporary outcomes.
- **Individual-level culture evidence.** The analysis connects historical ethnic-group exposure to individual survey responses, rather than only to country-level or regional economic outcomes.
- **Micro-foundation for persistence.** The paper ties historical evidence about betrayal during slave capture to models of cultural evolution, where rules of mistrust can persist when transmitted across generations.
- **Multiple identification strategies.** The paper layers controls, selection-on-observables calculations, IV estimates, falsification tests, and channel decompositions.
- **Internal versus external channels.** The distinction between ancestry-based exposure and location-based exposure separates cultural norms carried by people from institutional or geographic effects tied to places.
- **Broader contribution.** The paper became a canonical example of empirical work on historical origins of culture, showing how survey data, historical data, and causal designs can be combined.

3 Historical background and conceptual framework

3.1 Historical environment of insecurity

Early slave capture often involved warfare and large-scale raids. Over time, the trade generated insecurity within communities: people could protect themselves or profit by betraying neighbors, acquaintances, and even family members. Chiefs and local leaders could also become involved in slave trading, weakening trust in political authority.

Interpretation: The historical narrative provides the mechanism: repeated exposure to a world in which trusting others was costly could select for norms and beliefs based on mistrust.

3.2 Cultural persistence framework

Culture is viewed as a set of decision rules or heuristics used when information is imperfect or costly. Rules of trust or mistrust evolve according to payoffs in the relevant environment. If mistrust was useful during the slave trade, families and communities could transmit those beliefs across generations. Complementarities between mistrust and weak institutions can make low-trust equilibria persistent.

Interpretation: The paper therefore treats mistrust not as irrational, but as a historically adaptive response that may remain after the original environment disappears.

4 Data and measurement

4.1 Afrobarometer trust data

The survey data come from the 2005 Afrobarometer, covering 17 sub-Saharan African countries. After excluding respondents whose ethnic identity could not be matched cleanly, the potential sample contains 21,702 respondents. Trust responses are coded from 0 to 3: not at all, just a little, somewhat, and a lot. The five trust outcomes are trust in relatives, neighbors, local council, coethnics, and non-coethnics.

Interpretation: The dependent variables measure multiple social distances. The most striking tests are trust in relatives and neighbors, because the historical mechanism predicts mistrust even inside intimate networks.

4.2 Ethnicity-level slave export exposure

Slave export data are based on Nunn (2008). Country-level slave shipment data are disaggregated to ethnic groups using historical records of slaves' ethnic identities. The baseline measure is

$$\text{slave exports}_e = \ln\left(1 + \frac{\text{slaves taken from ethnicity } e}{\text{historical land area}_e}\right).$$

Interpretation: Normalizing by land area makes the exposure measure comparable across ethnic groups of different historical size and reduces skewness in the raw slave export counts.

4.3 Controls and channel measures

Individual controls include age, age squared, gender, urban residence, living conditions, education, religion, and occupation fixed effects. District controls include ethnic fractionalization and the share of the district population belonging to the respondent's ethnicity. Ethnicity controls include colonial and precolonial characteristics. The mechanism tests compare ethnicity-based exposure with location-based exposure.

Interpretation: The controls are designed to separate the slave trade from income, religion, education, district ethnic composition, colonial rule, and precolonial political development.

5 Models and empirical specifications

5.1 Baseline OLS

$$trust_{i,e,d,c} = \alpha_c + \beta slave\ exports_e + X'_{i,e,d,c}\Gamma + X'_{d,c}\Omega + X'_e\Phi + \varepsilon_{i,e,d,c}.$$

Interpretation: The coefficient β measures whether people whose ancestors were more heavily exposed to slave exports are less trusting today, conditional on individual, district, ethnicity, and country factors.

5.2 Instrumental variables

$$slave\ exports_e = \pi distance\ to\ coast_e + Controls_e + v_e,$$
$$trust_{i,e,d,c} = \alpha_c + \beta \widehat{slave\ exports}_e + Controls + \varepsilon_{i,e,d,c}.$$

Interpretation: The instrument uses the fact that slave raiding for overseas trade propagated inland from coastal export points. Ethnic groups farther from the coast were less exposed to external slave demand.

5.3 Selection-on-observables diagnostic

$$Altonji\ ratio = \frac{\beta^{full}}{\beta^{restricted} - \beta^{full}}.$$

Interpretation: Large ratios mean that unobservables would need to be much stronger than observables to eliminate the estimated effect.

5.4 Internal versus external channels

$$trust_{i,e,d,c} = \alpha_c + \beta_E EthnicityExposure_e + \beta_L LocationExposure_l + Controls + \varepsilon_{i,e,d,c}.$$

Interpretation: The ethnicity-based coefficient captures inherited internal norms. The location-based coefficient captures place-based institutions and social environments.

6 Identification and empirical design

6.1 Core identification problem

The observed correlation between slave exports and trust could reflect causal cultural transmission, but it could also reflect selection: ethnic groups that were initially less trusting or less developed may have been more vulnerable to enslavement. The design rules out alternative explanations using historical controls, selection diagnostics, IV, reduced-form falsification tests, and channel tests.

6.2 Historical controls

The paper controls for colonial population density, malaria ecology, jurisdictional hierarchy, settlement complexity, railway contact, European exploration, missionary activity, and other colonial or precolonial characteristics.

Interpretation: The goal is to separate the slave trade from colonial rule, initial prosperity, disease environments, and precolonial political development.

6.3 Distance-from-coast IV

Historical distance from the coast predicts slave exports because slaves had to be transported to overseas export points. The exclusion restriction is that distance affects current trust only through slave exports, after controlling for colonial influences, fishing, Saharan trade routes, and related geography.

Interpretation: The IV estimates are similar to OLS estimates, supporting the interpretation that selection into slave exports is not driving the result.

6.4 Falsification tests and mechanism tests

The reduced form compares the distance-trust relationship inside and outside Africa. The mechanism tests compare ancestry-based exposure with location-based exposure and control for the trustworthiness of local institutions and nearby groups.

Interpretation: These tests show that the distance-trust pattern is specific to the African historical setting and that internal cultural transmission appears more important than external local institutions.

7 Tables and figures

7.1 Figure 1: Ethnicity-level slave exports during the transatlantic and Indian Ocean slave trades

Read: Panel A maps transatlantic slave exports by ethnic group. Panel B maps Indian Ocean slave exports. Darker shading denotes more slaves taken. The figure shows strong within-country and cross-ethnic variation.

Economic message: The map is not just descriptive. It shows the cross-ethnic variation that powers the empirical design and illustrates why country-level analysis would miss important subnational exposure.

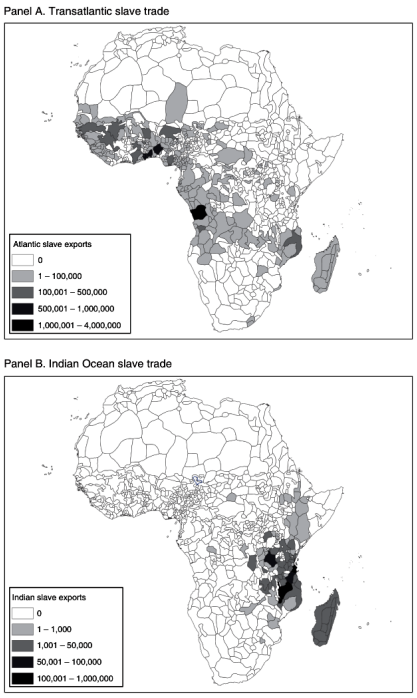

FIGURE 1

Note: Maps display the total number of slaves of each ethnicity shipped during the transatlantic and Indian Ocean slave trades.

Figure 1: Maps display the total number of slaves of each ethnicity shipped during the transatlantic and Indian Ocean slave trades.

7.2 Table 1: OLS Estimates of the Determinants of Trust in Neighbors; Table 2: OLS Estimates of the Determinants of the Trust of Others

Read: Table 1 shows that alternative slave-export measures all predict lower trust in neighbors. Table 2 extends the result to relatives, neighbors, local council, intragroup trust, and intergroup trust.

Economic message: The baseline pattern is broad: the slave trade is associated with distrust not only of outsiders but also of relatives and neighbors.

Table 1—OLS Estimates of the Determinants of Trust in Neighbors

Dependent variable: Trust of neighbors	Slave exports (thousands) (1)	Exports/ area (2)	Exports/ historical pop (3)	ln (1 + exports) (4)	ln (1 + exports/ area) (5)	ln (1 + exports/ historical pop) (6)
Estimated coefficient	−0.00068	−0.019	−0.531	−0.037	−0.159	−0.743
	[0.00014]	[0.005]	[0.147]	[0.014]	[0.034]	[0.187]
	(0.00015)	(0.005)	(0.147)	(0.014)	(0.034)	(0.187)
	{0.00013}	{0.005}	{0.165}	{0.015}	{0.034}	{0.212}
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
District controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	20,027	20,027	17,644	20,027	20,027	17,644
Number of ethnicities	185	185	157	185	185	157
Number of districts	1,257	1,257	1,214	1,257	1,257	1,214
R^2	0.16	0.16	0.15	0.15	0.16	0.15

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. Below each coefficient three standard errors are reported. The first, reported in square brackets, is standard errors adjusted for clustering within ethnic groups. The second, reported in parentheses, is standard errors adjusted for two-way clustering within ethnic groups and within districts. The third, reported in curly brackets, is T. G. Conley (1999) standard errors adjusted for two-dimensional spatial autocorrelation. The standard errors are constructed assuming a window with weights equal to one for observations less than five degrees apart and zero for observations further apart. The individual controls are for age, age squared, a gender indicator variable, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, and an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location. The district controls include ethnic fractionalization of each district and the share of the district's population that is the same ethnicity as the respondent.

(a) Table 1: baseline OLS for trust in neighbors.

Table 2—OLS Estimates of the Determinants of the Trust of Others

	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intra-group trust (4)	Inter-group trust (5)
ln (1 + exports/area)	−0.133***	−0.159***	−0.111***	−0.144***	−0.097***
	(0.037)	(0.034)	(0.021)	(0.032)	(0.028)
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
District controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	20,062	20,027	19,733	19,952	19,765
Number of ethnicity clusters	185	185	185	185	185
Number of district clusters	1,257	1,257	1,283	1,257	1,255
R^2	0.13	0.16	0.20	0.14	0.11

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. The individual controls are for age, age squared, a gender indicator variable, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, and an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location. The district controls include ethnic fractionalization in the district and the share of the district's population that is the same ethnicity as the respondent.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.
*Significant at the 10 percent level.

(b) Table 2: OLS for five trust outcomes.

7.3 Table 3: OLS Estimates with Additional Controls; Table 4: Selection on Observables

Read: Table 3 adds colonial and precolonial controls; coefficients remain negative. Table 4 reports Altonji-style ratios, with none below one and a median around four.

Economic message: The estimates are robust to rich historical controls, and hidden selection would need to be unusually strong to explain the result.

Table 3—OLS Estimates of the Determinants of the Trust of Others, with Additional Controls

	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intragroup trust (4)	Intergroup trust (5)
ln (1 + exports/area)	−0.178***	−0.202***	−0.129***	−0.188***	−0.115***
	(0.032)	(0.031)	(0.022)	(0.033)	(0.030)
Colonial population density	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Ethnicity-level colonial controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
District controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	16,709	16,679	15,905	16,636	16,473
Number of ethnicity clusters	147	147	146	147	147
Number of district clusters	1,187	1,187	1,194	1,186	1,184
R^2	0.13	0.16	0.21	0.16	0.12

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. The individual controls are for age, age squared, a gender indicator variable, five living conditions fixed effects, ten education fixed effects, 18 religion fixed effects, 25 occupation fixed effects, and an indicator for whether the respondent lives in an urban location. The district controls include ethnic fractionalization in the district and the share of the district's population that is the same ethnicity as the respondent. Ethnicity-level colonial controls include the prevalence of malaria, a 1400 urbanization indicator variable, eight fixed effects for the sophistication of precolonial settlement, the number of jurisdictional political hierarchies beyond the local community in the precolonial period, an indicator for integration with the colonial rail network, an indicator for contact with precolonial European explorers, and the number of missions per square kilometer during colonial rule. Colonial population density is the natural log of an ethnicity's population density during the colonial period.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.

(a) Table 3: additional controls.

Table 4—Using Selection on Observables to Assess the Bias from Unobservables

Controls in the restricted set	Controls in the full set	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intragroup trust (4)	Intergroup trust (5)
None	Full set of controls from equation (1)	4.31	4.23	3.03	4.13	3.32
None	Full set of controls from equation (1), ethnicity-level colonial controls, and colonial population density	11.54	6.98	2.65	9.22	3.80
Age, age squared, gender	Full set of controls from equation (1)	4.17	3.99	2.89	3.91	3.12
Age, age squared, gender	Full set of controls from equation (1), ethnicity-level colonial controls, and colonial population density	10.93	6.52	2.57	8.44	3.59

Notes: Each cell of the table reports ratios based on the coefficient for ln (1 + exports/area) from two individual-level regressions. In one, the covariates include the "restricted set" of control variables. Call this coefficient β^R. In the other, the covariates include the "full set" of controls. Call this coefficient β^F. In both regressions, the sample sizes are the same, and country fixed effects are included. The reported ratio is calculated as: $\beta^F/(\beta^R - \beta^F)$. See Table 3 for the description of the full set of controls from equation (1), the ethnicity-level colonial controls, and colonial population density.

(b) Table 4: selection-on-observables ratios.

7.4 Table 5: IV Estimates; Table 6: IV Estimates with Additional Controls

Read: Tables 5 and 6 use historical distance from the coast as an instrument for slave exports. The first stage is strong and second-stage estimates remain negative across trust outcomes.

Economic message: The IV evidence supports the view that the association is not solely driven by selection into the slave trade.

Table 5—IV Estimates of the Effect of the Slave Trade on Trust

	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intragroup trust (4)	Intergroup trust (5)
Second stage: Dependent variable is an individual's trust					
ln (1 + exports/area)	−0.190***	−0.245***	−0.221***	−0.251***	−0.174**
	(0.067)	(0.070)	(0.060)	(0.088)	(0.080)
Hausman test (p-value)	0.88	0.53	0.09	0.44	0.41
R^2	0.13	0.16	0.20	0.15	0.12
First stage: Dependent variable is ln (1 + exports/area)					
Historical distance of ethnic group from coast	−0.0014***	−0.0014***	−0.0014***	−0.0014***	−0.0014***
	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)
Colonial population density	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Ethnicity-level colonial controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
District controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	16,709	16,679	15,905	16,636	16,473
Number of clusters	147 / 1,187	147 / 1,187	146 / 1,194	147 / 1,186	147 / 1,184
F-stat of excl. instrument	26.9	26.8	27.4	27.1	27.0
R^2	0.81	0.81	0.81	0.81	0.81

Notes: The table reports IV estimates. The top panel reports the second-stage estimates, and the bottom panel reports first-stage estimates. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. The individual controls, district controls, ethnicity-level colonial controls, and colonial population density measures are described in Table 3. The null hypothesis of the Hausman test is that the OLS estimates are consistent.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.

(a) Table 5: IV estimates.

Table 6—IV Estimates of the Effect of the Slave Trade on Trust, with Additional Controls

	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intragroup trust (4)	Intergroup trust (5)
Second stage: Dependent variable is an individual's trust					
ln (1 + exports/area)	−0.172**	−0.271***	−0.262***	−0.254**	−0.189*
	(0.076)	(0.088)	(0.075)	(0.109)	(0.103)
Hausman test (p-value)	0.98	0.42	0.05	0.53	0.44
R^2	0.13	0.16	0.20	0.15	0.12
First stage: Dependent variable is ln (1 + exports/area)					
Historical distance of ethnic group from coast	−0.0015***	−0.0015***	−0.0015***	−0.0015***	−0.0015***
	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)	(0.0003)
Reliance on fishing	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Distances to Saharan city, route	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Colonial population density	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Ethnicity-level colonial controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
District controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	16,709	16,679	15,905	16,636	16,473
Number of clusters	147 / 1,187	147 / 1,187	146 / 1,194	147 / 1,186	147 / 1,184
F-stat of excl. instrument	21.7	21.6	22.2	21.8	21.6
R^2	0.81	0.81	0.81	0.81	0.81

Notes: The table reports IV estimates. The top panel reports the second-stage estimates, and the bottom panel reports first-stage estimates. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity and district levels. The individual controls, district controls, ethnicity-level colonial controls, and colonial population density measures are described in Table 3.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.
*Significant at the 10 percent level.

(b) Table 6: IV estimates with additional controls.

7.5 Table 7: Reduced Form within Africa and Asia; Table 8: Reduced Form within and outside Africa

Read: The reduced-form tests ask whether distance from the coast generally predicts trust everywhere. It predicts trust in Africa but not in comparison non-African samples.

Economic message: The falsification tests make the exclusion restriction more plausible: the distance-trust pattern appears where the slave trade mechanism is historically relevant.

Table 7—Reduced Form Relationship between the Distance from the Coast and Trust within Africa and Asia

	Trust of local government council			
	Afrobarometer sample		Asiabarometer sample	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Distance from the coast	0.00039***	0.00031***	−0.00001	0.00001
	(0.00009)	(0.00008)	(0.00010)	(0.00009)
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	No	Yes	No	Yes
Number of observations	19,913	19,913	5,409	5,409
Number of clusters	185	185	62	62
R^2	0.16	0.18	0.19	0.22

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. The dependent variable in the Asiabarometer sample is the respondent's answer to the question: "How much do you trust your local government?" The categories for the answers are the same in the Asiabarometer as in the Afrobarometer. Standard errors are clustered at the ethnicity level in the Afrobarometer regressions and at the location (city) level in the Asiabarometer and the WVS samples. The individual controls are for age, age squared, a gender indicator, education fixed effects, and religion fixed effects.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.
*Significant at the 10 percent level.

(a) Table 7: Africa and Asia reduced form.

Table 8—Reduced Form Relationship between the Distance from the Coast and Trust within and Outside of Africa

	Intergroup trust				
	Afrobarometer sample		WVS non-Africa sample		WVS Nigeria
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Distance from the coast	0.00039***	0.00037***	−0.00020	−0.00019	0.00054***
	(0.00013)	(0.00012)	(0.00014)	(0.00012)	(0.00010)
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	n/a
Individual controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	19,970	19,970	10,308	10,308	974
Number of clusters	185	185	107	107	16
R^2	0.09	0.10	0.09	0.11	0.06

Notes : The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. The dependent variable in the WVS sample is the respondent's answer to the question: "How much do you trust <nationality> people in general?" The categories for the respondent's answers are: "not at all," "not very much," "neither trust nor distrust," "a little," and "completely." The responses take on the values 0, 1, 1.5, 2, and 3. Standard errors are clustered at the ethnicity level in the Afrobarometer regressions and at the location (city) level in the Asiabarometer and the WVS samples. The individual controls are for age, age squared, a gender indicator, an indicator for living in an urban location, and occupation fixed effects.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.
*Significant at the 10 percent level.

(b) Table 8: inside and outside Africa.

7.6 Table 9: Identifying Channels of Causality; Table 10: Internal and External Channels

Read: Table 9 controls for local council trustworthiness, public goods, and the slave exposure of other ethnicities in the same location. Table 10 includes both ethnicity-based and location-based slave exposure.

Economic message: The channel evidence points mainly to internal cultural persistence, while still allowing a secondary role for place-based institutions.

Table 9—Identifying Channels of Causality

			Intergroup trust		
	Trust of local council (1)	(2)	Within town (3)	Within district (4)	Within province (5)
Ethnicity-based slave export measure (baseline measure)	−0.072***	−0.070***	−0.102***	−0.120***	−0.098***
	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.028)	(0.027)	(0.029)
Average slave export measure among other ethnicities in the same location			−0.037	−0.063**	−0.091***
			(0.029)	(0.030)	(0.035)
Council trustworthiness fixed effects	Yes	Yes	No	No	No
Five public goods fixed effects	No	Yes	No	No	No
Colonial population density	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Ethnicity-level colonial controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Baseline controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	12,827	12,203	9,673	12,513	15,999
Number of clusters	146/1,172	145/1,130	147/725	147/737	147/1,127
R^2	0.37	0.37	0.12	0.12	0.12

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity-based ethnicity level and at the location-based ethnicity level. "Average slave export measure among other ethnicities in the same location" is the average slave export measure of respondents in the Afrobarometer survey living in the same village, district, or region as the respondent. The "Five public goods fixed effects" are for the existence of the following public goods in the respondent's town/village: school, health clinic, sewage, piped water, and electricity. See Table 3 for a description of the baseline controls, the ethnnicity-level colonial controls, and the colonial population density variables.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.
*Significant at the 10 percent level.

(a) Table 9: local institutions and nearby groups.

Table 10—Identifying Channels of Causality

	Trust of relatives (1)	Trust of neighbors (2)	Trust of local council (3)	Intragroup trust (4)	Intergroup trust (5)
Ethnicity-based slave export measure (baseline measure)	−0.155***	−0.182***	−0.100***	−0.169***	−0.090***
	(0.029)	(0.029)	(0.023)	(0.033)	(0.030)
Location-based slave export measure	−0.045***	−0.045***	−0.045**	−0.043**	−0.047**
	(0.014)	(0.016)	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.020)
Colonial population density	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Ethnicity-level colonial controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Baseline controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Number of observations	15,999	15,972	15,221	15,931	15,773
Number of clusters	146/269	146/269	145/272	146/269	146/269
R^2	0.13	0.16	0.20	0.16	0.12

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates. The unit of observation is an individual. Standard errors are adjusted for two-way clustering at the ethnicity-based ethnicity level and at the location-based ethnicity level. "Ethnicity-based slave export measure" is our baseline measure of slave exports used throughout the article; it is the log of the number of slaves taken from an individual's ethnic group (normalized by land area). "Location-based slave export measure" is our alternative measure of slave exports, which is the log of the number of slaves taken from the location where an individual is currently living (normalized by land area). See Table 3 for a description of the baseline controls, the ethnicity-level colonial controls, and the colonial population density variables.

***Significant at the 1 percent level.
**Significant at the 5 percent level.
*Significant at the 10 percent level.

(b) Table 10: ancestry versus location exposure.

8 Short summary

- The paper studies the historical origins of trust within Africa.
- It links contemporary Afrobarometer trust responses to historical slave exports by ethnic group.
- OLS estimates are negative for all five trust outcomes.
- Results survive individual, district, country, precolonial, and colonial controls.
- IV estimates using distance from the coast are similar to OLS estimates.
- Channel tests show that internal norms explain more of the effect than place-based institutions.

9 Conclusion

9.1 Core conclusion

The slave trade had a persistent negative effect on trust within Africa. Individuals whose ancestors were more heavily exposed to slave exports report lower trust today.

9.2 Economic intuition

The slave trade made mistrust adaptive because betrayal by close contacts could prevent one's own enslavement or generate material gains. These beliefs could then persist through cultural transmission and institutional complementarities.

9.3 Policy implications

Low trust is not only a contemporary governance failure. It can be a historically transmitted response to violence. Trust-building policies may need credible institutions and repeated trustworthy interactions over long horizons.

9.4 Limitations

The historical measures are reconstructed from imperfect records; the IV exclusion restriction cannot be proven directly; trust is survey-based; and the exact intergenerational transmission mechanism is not directly observed.

9.5 Takeaway

The paper shows how history can become embedded in culture. The slave trade changed incentives inside African societies, and those changes still appear in contemporary trust patterns centuries later.